

MEI

GITHUB · NETLIFY · FORM EDITOR

The Self-Updating MEI Website

A website where adding a project or a person is filling out a form — the card, the map marker, the project page, and the team grid all update themselves.

HOW IT WORKS

The idea in one picture

Your content lives in small data files. A generator turns them into the finished pages. A form editor lets anyone add to those files without seeing code. GitHub stores it; Netlify rebuilds and publishes automatically on every change.

PIECE	WHAT IT IS
content/	One small file per project and per person — the only thing that changes day to day.
build.py	Reads the content + the design, writes the finished site. Runs automatically on Netlify.
/admin	The form editor (Decap CMS). Projects and People, each as a simple form.
GitHub	Stores everything and keeps a history of every change.
Netlify	Rebuilds and publishes the site within a minute of any change. Free. Adds HTTPS.

> **The payoff**
>
> Add a project in the form → it commits to GitHub → Netlify rebuilds → the new card, its own page, and its map marker are live. Nobody touches the layout. Removing a staff member is one checkbox.

The setup below is a one-time thing. Phases 1–2 get the site live; Phase 3 turns on the form login; Phase 4 points your domain.

1 Put the site on GitHub

~10 MINUTES · FREE ACCOUNT

1. Create a free account at **github.com** if you don't have one.
2. Click **New repository**. Name it `mei-website`, keep it **Public** (simplest for free hosting), and create it.
3. On the new repo's page, click **uploading an existing file**. Unzip `mei-website-repo.zip`, then drag **everything inside** the folder (not the outer folder itself) into the upload area. Commit.
4. Open `admin/config.yml` in GitHub, click the pencil to edit, and change the `repo:` line to your repo, e.g. `repo: ttrump95/mei-website`. Commit.

> **Prefer the command line?**
>
> You're comfortable with code, so if you'd rather: `git init`, commit the folder, and `git push` to the new repo. Same result.

2 Connect Netlify & go live

~5 MINUTES · FREE

1. Sign up at **netlify.com** with your GitHub account.
2. Click **Add new site → Import an existing project → GitHub**, and pick your `mei-website` repo.
3. Netlify reads `netlify.toml` and fills in the build settings automatically (`python3 build.py` , publish `_site`). Just click **Deploy**.
4. A minute later you'll have a live address like `random-name.netlify.app` . Open it — the full site, map working, from your data files.

> **That's the site live.**
> From here on, any change pushed to GitHub (by you, or by the form editor) rebuilds and republishes automatically. You could stop here and edit content by hand in GitHub. Phase 3 adds the nicer form login.

3 Turn on the form editor login

THE ONE FIDDLY PART — DO IT ONCE

The `/admin` form editor needs permission to save changes to your GitHub repo. You grant that by registering a GitHub "OAuth app" and handing its keys to Netlify. Follow it exactly and it's about 10 minutes.

3a — Register a GitHub OAuth app

1. On GitHub: your avatar → **Settings → Developer settings → OAuth Apps → New OAuth App**.
2. Fill in: **Application name** `MEI Content Manager` ; **Homepage URL** your Netlify address (or `https://millereng.net`); **Authorization callback URL** exactly `https://api.netlify.com/auth/done` .
3. Click **Register application**. Copy the **Client ID**. Click **Generate a new client secret** and copy that too (you only see it once).

3b — Give the keys to Netlify

1. In your Netlify site: **Site configuration → Access & security → OAuth** (older menus: *Access control*). Under **Authentication providers**, click **Install provider**.
2. Choose **GitHub**, paste the **Client ID** and **Client Secret**, and save.

3c — Log in and try it

1. Go to `your-site.netlify.app/admin` . Click **Login with GitHub** and authorize.

2. You'll see **Projects** and **People**. Open a project to confirm the form loads. You're in.

> **Two things to know**
>
> Anyone who edits must have access to the repo — add them as a **collaborator** on GitHub (repo → Settings → Collaborators) and they'll each need a free GitHub account. And the callback URL must be *exactly* `https://api.netlify.com/auth/done` — a typo here is the usual reason login fails.

4 Point millereng.net at it

ONE-TIME DNS CHANGE · NO DOWNTIME

1. In Netlify: **Domain management → Add a domain**, enter **millereng.net**.
2. Netlify shows either nameservers or DNS records. Log in wherever the domain is registered, open its DNS settings, and enter those exact values.
3. Wait for it to take effect (minutes to a few hours). HTTPS is added automatically and free. The old site keeps serving until the switch completes, so there's no gap.

5 Everyday use: adding content

THE WHOLE POINT

Add a project

1. Go to **millereng.net/admin**, log in, open **Projects → New Project**.
2. Fill the form: title, a URL slug (lowercase-with-dashes), market, city, location, year, client, services, overview, and tick **Feature on homepage** if wanted.
3. Enter **Latitude** and **Longitude** for the map marker (see the tip below), and optionally upload a photo.
4. Click **Publish**. A minute later the card, its own page, and the map marker are live.

Add or remove a person

1. **People → New Person**: name, role, bio, sort order, optional headshot → Publish.
2. To remove someone, open their record and untick **Active** (keeps the history) → Publish.

> **Getting latitude & longitude (30 seconds)**

Open **google.com/maps**, right-click the project's location, and the first line of the menu shows two numbers — that's **latitude, longitude** (e.g. `38.3498, -81.6326`). Latitude goes in the Latitude box, longitude (the negative one, for WV) in the Longitude box.

If you'd rather not use the form

Every project and person is a small file in `content/` on GitHub. You can edit or add one there directly and Netlify rebuilds the same way — handy for you, and it needs none of the Phase 3 login setup.

Quick troubleshooting

SYMPTOM	FIX
A build "failed" on Netlify	Open the deploy log. Usually a data file has a typo (a missing comma/quote in the JSON). Fix that file and it rebuilds.
/admin won't log in	Re-check the callback URL is exactly `https://api.netlify.com/auth/done` and the Client ID/Secret are pasted correctly in Netlify.
A new project has no map marker	It's missing Latitude/Longitude, or they're swapped. WV longitude is negative.